



To help us understand how life forms on the planet are related to each other, scientists organize them into six large groups called kingdoms. Once there were only two groups—animals and plants—but these were divided further after the discovery of invisible microscopic organisms.

FUNGI



Types of organism: Mushrooms, molds, yeasts

Distribution: Worldwide

Fungi used to be classed as plants until scientists discovered that they cannot make their own food. Instead they gain their energy by breaking down dead plants and animals. They consist of complex single or multiple cells and are chemically and genetically closer to animals than to plants.

PLANTS



Types of organism: Green algae, mosses, conifers, flowering plants
Distribution: Worldwide, though fewer in polar areas

Plants are multicelled complex organisms that can make their own food. They range from tiny mosses to enormous trees and have managed to colonize most areas of the world, including the oceans. Plants play a vital role in oxygenating the atmosphere.

ANIMALS



Types of organism: Insects, fish, mammals, crustaceans, reptiles, amphibians

Distribution: Worldwide

Animals range from the very simple—with no brain, no nervous system, and no spinal cord, such as a sponge—to highly complex mammals like ourselves. Animals can't make their own food, so they must obtain it by eating members of the other kingdoms.

We know our place—
king and queen of the
cat family.

